

dinnertime; start around 4:00 PM and you should be fine. At some point, you'll learn that spaghetti with meat sauce and a roast (buy an eye-of-round roast, put it in the Crock-Pot with cream of mushroom soup and/or dried onion soup mix, cook on low for 4–6 hours) takes far less time than you think.

8. Rename your creations: At my house, a burned entrée might become blackened chicken.

— **Julie Rains**

7 Ways to Brown-Bag It with Style

Finding time to pack your lunch for work each day can feel pretty overwhelming. Trying to be creative about it can be even more frustrating. Following are ideas to help you get started, and stay psyched, about joining the brown-bag movement.

1. Large batch items

This can work well if you have several small containers to pack up ahead of

time and toss in with your other lunch items. The smaller plastic containers or a small thermos from the thrift store are helpful items. Zingy pasta salad, chili, soup, quiche, fried rice, pizza, tabouleh, pancit, or lo mein noodle dishes are some ideas for large batch items to round out your lunch repertoire.

2. Pre-pack some “grab and takes”

“Grab and takes” is the term we use in our house for those little extras that are easily eaten at your desk, on the run, or in the car. One of my favorites is the large packages of restaurant-style tortilla chips from the bulk warehouse stores. They are easy to break down into pint or snack-size resealable containers. They are also much sturdier than regular tortilla chips and hold up to some seriously sturdy dips. Popcorn, roasted almonds, homemade trail mix, pretzels

